

Christopher Columbus

Accidental discovery

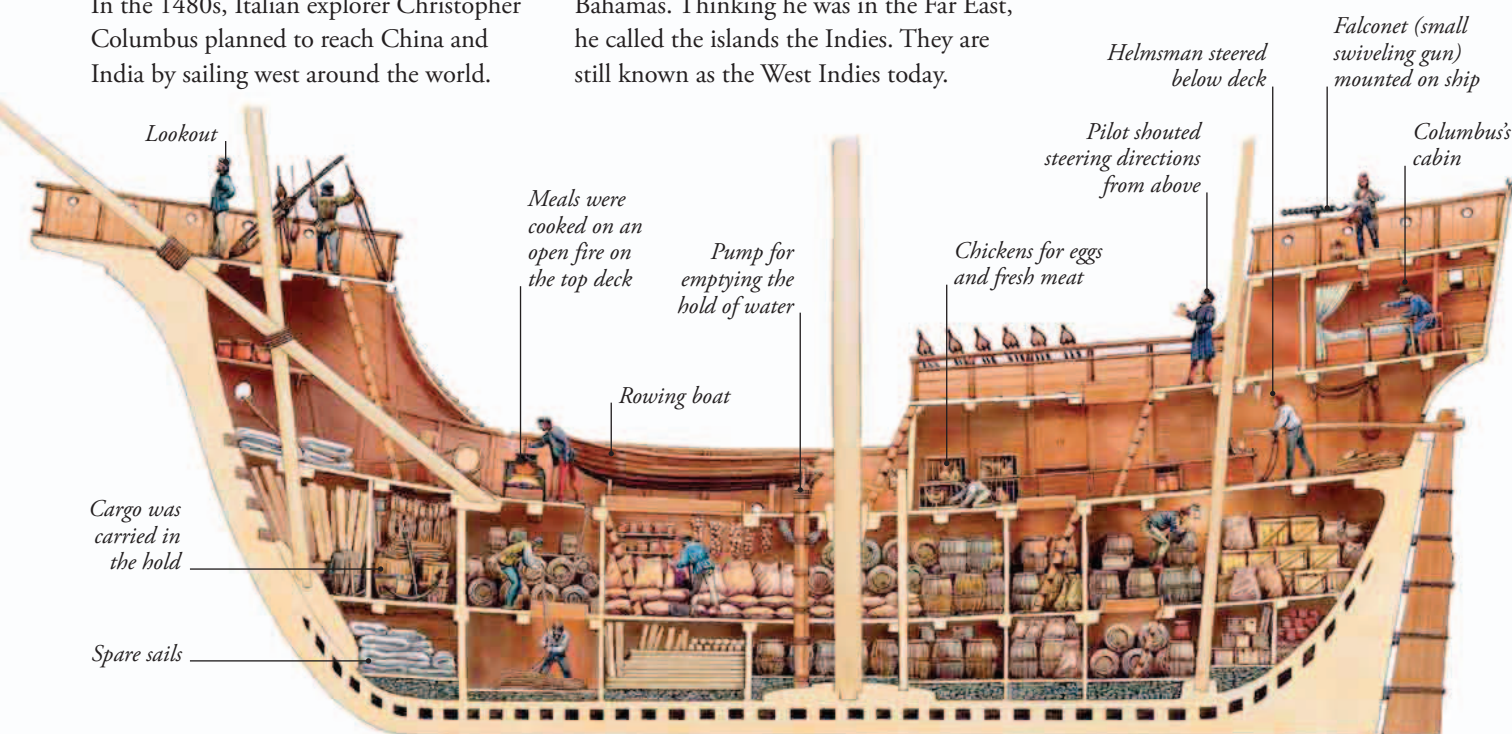
Date 1492–1493

Object of voyage Trade route

Distance traveled 10,000 miles (16,000 km)

In the 1480s, Italian explorer Christopher Columbus planned to reach China and India by sailing west around the world.

He did not know that America was in his way. Columbus crossed the Atlantic with his fleet of three Spanish ships, landing in the Bahamas. Thinking he was in the Far East, he called the islands the Indies. They are still known as the West Indies today.



▲ **INSIDE THE SANTA MARIA**
Columbus's flagship, Santa Maria, was 62 ft (19 m) long. It had a crew of about 40 men, and was stocked with enough food and water to last for months. Santa Maria was accompanied on the voyage by two smaller ships, Niña and Pinta.

Ferdinand Magellan

Around the world

Date 1519–1522

Object of voyage Trade route

Distance traveled 37,000 miles (60,000 km)

Like Columbus, Ferdinand Magellan hoped to reach the rich trading ports of the Far East by sailing west. He left Spain in 1519 with three ships and 237 crew, and had to sail around the southern tip of South America before he could cross the vast Pacific. The journey took far longer than expected, and when Magellan was killed in the Philippines, his surviving crew decided to cross the Indian Ocean and sail home around Africa. They got back to Spain in 1522, having sailed around the world.

HMS Beagle

Charting the coasts

Date 1831–1836

Object of voyage Coastal surveying

Distance traveled 40,000 miles (64,400 km)

The world's oceans were charted by many surveying expeditions in the 18th and 19th centuries. They included the five-year voyage of HMS *Beagle* around the world, for which the captain hired the young British naturalist Charles Darwin. While on board, Darwin made some of the first serious studies of marine life, ocean water, and coral reefs.

► GALÁPAGOS ISLAND

Some of Darwin's most important discoveries were made on the eastern Pacific Galápagos Islands. The data he collected here was vital to his later work on evolution. This inlet on San Cristóbal island is named Darwin Cove in his honor.



HMS Challenger

Research ship

Date 1872–1876

Object of voyage Oceanography

Distance traveled 80,000 miles (130,000 km)

The voyage of HMS *Challenger* was the first serious attempt to understand the oceans. The ship crossed the Atlantic, Pacific, and Indian oceans while the scientists on board measured and sampled everything they could. In the process, they were the first to discover the nature of the ocean floor, with its ridges, trenches, and isolated seamounts.

